



Jolicloud: The new social OS for netbooks

Netbooks have become the buzz word today. As they become more popular, it becomes obvious that netbooks are very different from laptops and should be treated differently. Tariq Krim, the founder of Netvibes, is one of the many who are not satisfied with the OS running on their netbooks. And this led to the creation of Jolicloud (an OS based on Ubuntu Netbook Remix) that's designed specifically for netbooks, and the beta version of which is to be released very soon.

Jolicloud is currently at the closed alpha testing stage and only offers downloads on an invitation basis. The download is a LiveCD installer of around 600 MB, distributed in ISO format. You will have to use a USB creator software to mount the ISO file on a USB drive before it can be installed on a netbook.

One of the major highlights of the OS is its light weight and the absence of most of the applications one would normally use in your day-to-day life. Jolicloud has even decided to do away with the Synaptics Package Manager and replaced it with a Prism dashboard called My Jolicloud. The dashboard is the starting point of your Jolicloud Web-centric experience. It contains news and notifications of the software updates for your netbook.



The application panel functions just like the iPhone App Store where you can choose the applications you want and install it in your netbook, easily and quickly. You are not restricted to install only desktop-based applications. Most of the popular Web-based apps such as Google Docs, Zoho Office, and YouTube can also be installed in your system (basically, they are just a customised build of Prism).

The app also has a social network built in, where you can 'follow' other Jolicloud users (a la Twitter) and get updates on what they install on their systems (a la Wakoopa).

MontaVista 6 targets multiple platforms

MontaVista Software recently announced the general availability of new Market Specific Distributions (MSDs) of MontaVista Linux 6. By working closely with its semiconductor partners to deliver the right combination of features and functionality for each platform, MontaVista remains committed to providing the broadest hardware support in the embedded Linux market, and aligning the embedded Linux supply chain.

These MSDs are the first of a broad family of semiconductor feature-compatible, market-specific Linux distributions announced in May this year. Built on a common framework, and optimised for the respective hardware platform and its target market, an MSD is designed to support the full breadth of functionality provided by the semiconductor vendors, be feature compatible with the semiconductor vendors' Linux technology, and provide the value-add features and quality MontaVista is known for. MSDs may be customised and optimised for the target application, allowing developers to easily create a tailored software distribution that fully exploits the hardware specific features.

MontaVista Linux 6 was announced on May 12, 2009 and made generally available on August 14, 2009. More than 40 MSDs are being planned and developed and will be made available in the coming months. It also provides support for the broadest range of hardware platforms from each of the leading semiconductor vendors.

MS's open source strategist quits

Sam Ramji, Microsoft's key figure in engaging with open source developers, has left the building. He's quitting Microsoft and going to work for a start-up, leaving a number of Microsoft initiatives, including contributions to the Linux kernel and its 'CodePlex' open source code-sharing initiative, somewhat in the air.



That Microsoft has worked with the open source developer community at all would be news to many. Apart from being fodder for analysts and public relations, there's very little business incentive for Microsoft to really co-operate with free software in most of the areas it operates in. From Web servers to Web development platforms, compilers to dynamic languages, open source competes directly with Microsoft's own products.

Mesa 7.6 to be released before October '09

Mesa 7.6 provides support for a number of new OpenGL extensions with its software rasterizer and the Intel i965 driver mostly, there is the rewritten Radeon/R200/R300 driver that uses the buffer manager (a.k.a. the Radeon 3D driver re-write), GL_EXT_framebuffer_object support for ATI when using the TTM memory manager, proper OpenGL 1.5 support for the ATI R300 series (and VBO + OQ support), and the assembly shader rework. This, in fact, is just a small portion of the changes. Mesa 7.6 is quite a huge update compared to Mesa 7.5, which was just released in July.